Most of the institutions currently engaged in shaping India's foreign policy are built on the edifice of the British Raj. They function with varying degrees of efficacy in different situations but cannot be said to represent an Indian strategic ethos. Subrahmanyam, India's leading strategic analyst, argued that the key reason for this was the absence of a strategic culture from the pre-British era. Prior to British rule various princely states focused on their own security in an ad hoc manner and there was little emphasis on global strategy. Since the princes saw a threat only from one another and not to India as a whole, they did not care to think about a strategy for the defence of the subcontinent. During British rule, the Raj framed its interests in terms of what benefited the empire and no Indian took part or was allowed to be involved in formulation of strategy.[3]

Subrahmanyam goes on to argue that after 1947, India saw itself as a status-quo-oriented, non-expansionist power. It, therefore, did not have the 'paranoid sense of insecurity' that leads to serious strategic planning.[4] The country's early post-British era leaders assumed that if India does not threaten others, others will leave India alone and refrain from threatening its security. In addition, civilian control of the military under domestic-policy-oriented politicians prevented the development of a large Indian military–industrial complex. India was thus denied the post-Independence institutional structure that could encourage strategic thought, which in its essence is about national security. More than strategic security it is national pride that defined India's foreign policy in the immediate aftermath of Independence.

Under Nehru, the military and intelligence apparatus were treated as tactical executors of policy and kept away from decision making. This ensured civilian supremacy but did not create vertical and horizontal integration in planning for national security. The Ministry of Defence, manned by civilians, kept the three uniformed services – the army, navy and air force – out of policymaking. Most of the proposals considered by the